

Macronectes giganteus

Southern giant petrel



Length 36 in (92 cm)
Weight 11 lb (5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

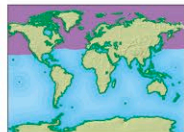
Location Circumpolar around Antarctica

Large and aggressive, with a large bill capable of opening intact carcasses, this bird is one of a few petrels to obtain a significant amount of its food on land. Males in particular prey at seal and penguin colonies and feed on the bodies of whales washed ashore. The adult usually has mottled, grayish brown plumage, but some individuals may be white with black flecks.



Fulmarus glacialis

Northern fulmar



Length 18–20 in (45–50 cm)
Weight 25–30 oz (700–850 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location Arctic, North Pacific, and North Atlantic oceans

The fulmar is a common bird of northern waters, flying on characteristic stiff, straight wings. Its numbers have increased dramatically in the past 200 years, particularly in temperate waters of the North Atlantic, possibly due to the increase in offal available from trawlers gutting fish at sea. As well as scavenging from ships, it eats fish, squid, and animal plankton, seizing most of its prey at the surface but sometimes plunging into the water.



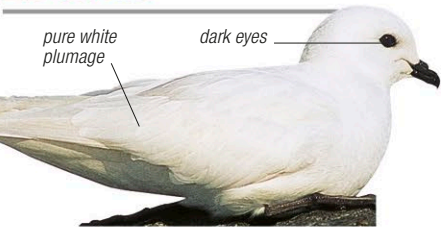
Pagodroma nivea

Snow petrel



Length 12½ in (32 cm)
Weight 9–16 oz (250–450 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location Circumpolar around Antarctica



One of the few birds, apart from penguins, that breed on the Antarctic continent, the dovelike snow petrel is rarely seen away from pack ice. It may nest inland, up to 185 miles (300 km) from open water, but breeding is much affected by snowfall, and in some years only one in 5 nesting sites may be occupied. It fiercely defends its nest from other petrels, spitting a foul-smelling oil at them.

Pterodroma cahow

Bermuda petrel



Length 13 in (33 cm)
Weight 9 oz (250 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Endangered

Location Bermuda (ocean range 625 miles/1,000 km)

One of the world's rarest seabirds, the Bermuda petrel was brought to the brink of extinction as long ago as the 17th century, as a result of predation by introduced mammals and competition for nesting sites with the white-tailed tropicbird. Conservation measures are helping this black, gray, and white petrel to stage a gradual recovery.

Pachyptila vittata

Broad-billed prion



Length 11 in (28 cm)
Weight 5–8 oz (150–225 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location South Atlantic, South Pacific, S. Indian Ocean

This medium-gray bird has a darker "M" across both wings, and white underparts. Its bill is broad, with comblike plates used for filtering planktonic prey from the sea. It feeds mainly by "hydroplaning"—with wings outstretched and feet paddling, pushing the sieving bill through the surface water to trap its prey.

Oceanites oceanicus

Wilson's storm petrel



Length 6½ in (17 cm)
Weight 1⅞ oz (40 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location Pacific, Atlantic, Indian Ocean

A small, soot-black bird with a conspicuous white rump, the storm petrel is often said to be one of the world's most numerous seabirds, with populations running into millions. It breeds around Antarctica, but during the southern winter, it flies north, especially to the northern Indian and Atlantic oceans. It rarely

alights on the sea, but catches small fish and crustaceans when pattering on or hovering just above the surface. It can detect prey by smell, and it has been suggested that prey are attracted when the bird stirs its yellow-webbed feet around in the water. When faced with predators, this petrel may squeak and eject stomach oil at them.



Puffinus puffinus

Manx shearwater



Length 12–14 in (31–36 cm)
Weight 13–18 oz (375–500 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location Atlantic

This shearwater breeds in the North Atlantic, forming colonies on offshore islands—mainly Skomer and Skokholm off the western coast of Wales, and Rhum in the Outer Hebrides—filling the

air with calls that sound like screams and wails. Although it feeds at sea by day, it is active at the colonies only after dark, to avoid attack by gulls. This bird usually nests in an earth burrow, but it sometimes lays its single egg under

HOOKE D BILL
The Manx shearwater has a relatively slender and hooked bill, with which it seizes fish at the water surface. It may swim a few yards underwater to pursue its prey.



rocks. Both parents incubate the egg, working in shifts of 6–7 days, and they feed the chick for up to 70 days, leaving it about a week before it starts to fly. As winter approaches, the shearwater flies south to warmer waters off Brazil.

COLORATION



Black above and white below, this bird produces a characteristic black, then white flash as it flies over the sea, looking for small schooling fish such as sprat.